

IRAQI KURDISTAN: DISPLACED PEOPLE

What's life like in a camp for displaced people? Young Syrians in Kawergosk Camp near Erbil in Iraqi Kurdistan were provided cameras and trained to take photos of life in their camp from their point of view.

The trainer of these young photographers is a long-time, contributing photographer to National Geographic with extensive experience in many countries of conflict, including Afghanistan.

Photos from Kawergosk are on public display -- a 370-meter photographic panorama -- in Paris on the Seine until October 12th. Below is a NYT article on the exhibition.

Also see: <http://www.webistan.com/exhibition/dream-of-humanity-2/>

- - - - -

The World Fact Book produced by the CIA (not the Culinary Institute of America) says Syria's estimated population in July 2014 was 17 million. Apparently, this figure excludes Syrians who fled their country, though the The World Fact Book doesn't mention this important distinction. Other sources put Syria's population at 23 million.

More than 4 million displaced Syrians (95% of all Syrians who fled their country) are in just five countries: Jordan, Lebanon, Turkey, Iraq, Egypt.

- **Jordan** (The World Fact Book: population 8 million, area 89,000 sqkm), 650,000 Syrian displaced people.
- **Lebanon** (The World Fact Book: July 2015 estimated population 6 million, area 10,000 sqkm) 1.2 million Syrian displaced people.
- **Turkey** (The World Fact Book: July 2015 estimated population 79 million, area 784,000 sqkm) 1.9 million Syrian displaced people.
- **Iraq** (The World Fact Book: July 2015 estimated population 37 million, area 438,000 sqkm) 250,000 Syrian displaced persons. More than 95% of Syrians who fled to Iraq are in Iraqi Kurdistan.
- **Egypt** (The World Fact Book: July 2015 estimated population 88 million, area 1 million sqkm) 132,000 Syrian displaced people.

These numbers refer only to registered Syrians. Likely, many thousands more are unregistered.

And these figures do not include Syrians displaced within their own country, about 8 million.

Thus, half of Syria's 23 million population is displaced, requiring much higher, stable levels of humanitarian assistance. This is essential to keep them closer to home in order to avoid tragedy inherent in the dangerous dash to Europe.

Turkey provides humanitarian assistance to some 2 million displaced Syrians. Reportedly, Turkey has the best constructed, organized, and managed camps, fully funded by the Turkish Government.

- - - - -

Recent newsmaking movements of displaced people toward Europe highlight the urgent requirement for more acute, concerted attention being focused on the problem.

The solution is not just humanitarian assistance, of course. It's more political. Over the years Turkey has demonstrated strong capacities to control its borders. Its border with Syria was quite well sealed. But more recently, ISIS personnel and materiel have gotten through, but Kurdish fighters to support the battle over Kobane have not. And now, displaced people have been allowed to leave its shores on dangerous journeys to Europe.

Resettlement in Europe and America is not a solution. There are more than 50 million displaced people in the world. Resettling a few hundred thousand in Europe and America is but another proverbial drop in the bucket.

At the very least, improving temporary living conditions as close to home as possible would be more helpful in preventing tragedy, heartbreakingly demonstrated in the photo of little Alan Kurdi who washed up on the Turkish shoreline.

Fleeing home is almost always the last option. It's all about loss. Armed conflict at home not only threatens personal security, it also causes economic collapse and loss of livelihoods. Much of the video footage of fleeing migrants show mostly young men.

Whatever they are technically called -- internally displaced persons (IDPs), asylum seekers, refugees, economic migrants -- they are all displaced people who felt compelled to flee their homes.

All face the same or similar realities: exile from homeland and loss of community, loss of livelihood, inadequate safety and security, severely disrupted lives, an unstable present and an uncertain future, limits and boredom, suspended lives existing in temporary locations under temporary conditions for years, decades, even forever.

It's more push than pull; it's more the push of the situation than the pull of the destination. For some it's not about leaving home forever, adopting a new home, and integrating into another society and building a new life. They seek legal residence in Europe or America so they can obtain travel documents, then return to their home of origin later when the situation improves. Foreign travel documents allow a way out if the return doesn't work out.

There are lessons to be learned from Iraqi Kurdistan.

Before 1991, Iraqi Kurdistan was a source of displaced people forced to flee their homes, disconnecting them from their sense of community and from their lands and livelihoods.

After 1991, Iraqi Kurdistan became a refuge for displaced people (DPs) forced to flee their homes, disconnecting them from their sense of community and from their lands and livelihoods.

The difference? Security. Primarily, just security.

Before 1991, thousands of rural communities in Iraqi Kurdistan were destroyed by the regime of Saddam Hussein, and made uninhabitable so no living thing would survive. People, animals, and even trees were not allowed to survive.

Displaced people fled to neighboring countries, some to cities and towns, others to some 75 "collective towns" that continue today, away from their original communities. Collective towns were substandard communities where displaced people existed, not lived, where they could be better observed and controlled by the regime of Saddam Hussein. In some ways, there were not unlike reservations for Native Americans.

Ethnic cleansing followed by resettlement by Iraqis from elsewhere in the country continued to cause displacement almost up until the 2003 war began.

After 1991, security was assisted, not assured, by a no-fly zone established by a small US-led coalition in 1991 that continued up to the 2003 war. Notably, it wasn't a no-drive zone. All four neighbors conducted or supported armed ground incursions into Iraqi Kurdistan. For example, during the 1990s Syria harbored the PKK that attacked numerous rural communities in Iraqi Kurdistan. Many remain uninhabited today.

Throughout the 1990s the regime of Saddam Hussein threatened Iraqi Kurdistan by establishing a militarized demarcation line that effectively cut Iraqi Kurdistan in half and separated the northern part, what became known as the Kurdistan Region, from the rest of the country. This led to regional elections, the first internationally-observed elections in Iraq, and the formation of the Iraqi Kurdistan Parliament (IKP) and the Kurdistan Regional Government (KRG) in mid-1992. The IKP and KRG have continued to today.

Both Turkey and Iran sent armed forces into Iraqi Kurdistan. Both bombed or shelled border areas, sometimes killing civilian citizens of Iraqi Kurdistan.

The Kurdistan Region became a haven for displaced people fleeing all four neighbors. During the 1990s, Iranians fled to the Region. So, too, Turkish citizens. For example, Makhmour Camp south of Erbil includes families who fled Turkey over twenty years ago, in 1994.

Iraqi citizens fleeing the regime of Saddam Hussein, including members of Prime Minister Abadi's (and former Prime Minister Maliki's) Islamic Dawa Party, who sought refuge in the Kurdistan Region during the 1990s until 2003.

And there were citizens of Syria who fled to the Region during the 1990s, and also after 2003 before the Arab Spring demonstrations began in 2011. In 2004 a violent incident in Qamishli (Syria) where many were killed caused Syrian residents to flee to Iraqi Kurdistan.

The 1990s in the Kurdistan Region was a time of double economic embargo, severe travel restrictions, isolation without telecommunications with the outside world, sanctions-causing economic collapse including widespread loss of livelihoods, grossly inadequate public revenue to support basic services, and threatening neighbors.

Nevertheless, in spite of all these constraints and restrictions there was a reasonable sense of security and many thousands of citizens of Iraqi Kurdistan soon returned from Iran and Turkey,. Hundreds of communities were reconstructed and resettled. And many who fled to Europe, America, and even Australia many years ago have returned. Home is home.

Despite internal armed conflicts and destructive rivalries Iraqi Kurdistan has developed into one of the most pluralistic, personally secure, and politically stable areas in a "normally" volatile and violent Middle East. Some 2 million displaced people have voted it so, with their feet.

It didn't happen by itself. It's about leadership.

Today, the area of Iraqi Kurdistan, where traditional Kurdistanis predominate outside ISIS control, includes almost all of its original territory. Saddam's demarcation line that cut Iraqi Kurdistan nearly in half ceased to exist when his regime ceased to exist.

This area includes about 10 million people, including 2 million displaced people from other parts of Iraq and from Syria. This is 27% of Iraq's total population. The World Fact Book July 2015 estimated population figure for Iraq is 37 million. This seems excessively high given the high number who left the country. It also seems excessively high according to projections based on the 27 million figure submitted by the Iraqi Government and approved by the UN in December 2003, and the 30 million figure

stated in the 2008 Comprehensive Food Security and Vulnerability Analysis conducted by the UN-WFP and the Gol.

What this means is that, while Iraqi Kurdistan is responsible for no less than 27% of Iraq's total population regarding vital security and other basic public services, the KRG is receiving no where near 27% of national public revenue.

To compound the situation, if and when military action is initiated to retake Mosul it is being projected that some 500,000 additional displaced people would leave their homes. Most would likely flee to Iraqi Kurdistan.

The New York Times
10 Sep 2015

INTERNATIONAL ARTS

Photo Exhibition Puts Syrian Refugees on the Seine

By ELIAN PELTIER

**A photo by the 15-year-old Mohammad Husein in the refugee camp at Kawergosk, Iraq, is part of Reza Deghati's project "Exile Voices."
Credit Mohammad Husein/Reza Visual Academy**

PARIS — For the next month, large photos of Syrian refugees camped in northern Iraq will dominate the banks of the Seine just where it flows past the elegant Jardin des Tuileries, bringing to well-heeled Parisians a look at a world stripped of comfort.

In one photo, a man splashes his face with water with an expression of effort and relief — a reminder that for the refugees, even washing cannot be taken for granted.

The French-Iranian photographer Reza Deghati, known as Reza, curated this exhibition to show the daily lives of Syrian refugees in a camp at Kawergosk, in Iraqi Kurdistan. Rather than join the thousands of people heading to Europe, these Syrians fled the civil war and remained in the Middle East, ending up in camps opened by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees.

Reza set up images documenting their lives on 16.5-foot-high tarpaulins along 405 yards of the right bank. The exhibition, "Dreams of Humanity," showcases 27 photographs (including the one of the man splashing his face with water) taken by 20 Syrian children and teenagers aged 10 to 17 who live in the Kawergosk camp and have been Reza's photography students since December 2013.

**Maya's photo of her frozen sneakers.
Credit Maya Rostam/Reza Visual Academy**

The exhibition also includes smaller portraits from Reza and large black-and-white portraits of Syrian refugee children in Jordan taken by the Dubai photographer Ali Bin Thalith, the secretary general of the Hamdan bin Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum International Photography Award. That foundation is the exhibition's sponsor, and Reza invited the United Nations agency to promote its actions in refugee camps. The show was also organized in conjunction with the Paris mayor's office.

"Dreams of Humanity" is the first show in Reza's long-term project, "Exile Voices." Since 2013 the photographer, who lives in Paris, has visited the Kawergosk camp five times. He hopes to go back next month and then start similar classes in other camps, in collaboration with the refugee agency, and eventually exhibit the students' works in other cities.

"I want to show their lives to the entire world and in a universal language," Reza told about 200 visitors to the exhibition one evening last month. "Those kids have lost the paradise every kid has."

As Parisians and tourists walk along the river bank, they can see portraits of refugee children playing on rope swings, doing their homework or hiding behind a tent to kiss each other.

A renowned photographer — he is a longtime contributor to National Geographic — Reza is also a teacher and humanitarian. For this project he is working with a Syrian journalist, Mohammad Qaddri, who lives in the camp and to whom he sends assignments for the children every two or three weeks, such as taking photographs of their breakfast. The assignments may sound simple, but each one can translate into a poignant portrait of the inhumanity of camp life — especially for children. Reza looks at every picture in his Paris office, he said, and sends them back with comments.

"The cameras are like a lifebuoy you would give to a shipwrecked person," Reza said in an interview at the exhibition. "So I want to make those kids committed" to photography. He added: "I want to make them uninhibited."

As arresting as the photos are the stories behind them. On a December morning in 2013, Maya Rostam, one of Reza's 20 students, was late for her first class. When he asked the 13-year-old Syrian girl why she couldn't join the group on time, she simply handed him her camera. On the screen was a picture of a small pair of frozen sneakers lying on the cracked ground. "That's why I was late, sir," Maya told Reza, explaining that the bitter cold had frozen her shoes so that she had to wait for the ice to melt slightly before she could put them on.

"I couldn't hold my tears," Reza said as he stood in front of the photograph.

The photographer makes himself accessible to those interested in the exhibition, posting on his Facebook page when he will visit and taking people through it several times a month.

"I like that he takes the time to meet us," said Lisa Nguyen, 27, a bank employee and photography buff here who learned that Reza would be at the exhibition one day from his Facebook page. "I also like that he is showing us the exhibition himself. People usually devote less and less time for others in our society."

The New York Times
25 Sep 2015

End in Sight to Tide of Migrants Entering Europe, U.N. Says

By SEWELL CHANSEPT

LONDON — The flood of Syrian refugees pouring into the heart of Europe is unlikely to ease anytime soon, and worsening conditions in Iraq could send new waves of displaced people onto the Continent, United Nations officials warned on Friday.

"I don't see it stopping," Amin Awad, director of the Middle East and North Africa division of the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, told reporters in Geneva. If anything, he said, the thousands of refugees arriving daily at the borders of European countries may be "the tip of the iceberg."

The warnings came as the impact of the European Union's decision on Tuesday to apportion 120,000

migrants among member countries — in some cases, against their leaders' wishes — continued to ripple across the Continent.

Perhaps the most vitriolic demonstrations were in Finland, which abstained from the vote on Tuesday. Images of a protester wearing a robe and hood resembling those of the Ku Klux Klan ricocheted across the Internet on Friday.

In the city of Lahti, about 60 miles northeast of the capital, Helsinki, demonstrators chanted, pelted rocks and shot fireworks at a bus of asylum seekers at a processing center. In the nearby town of Kouvola, a gasoline bomb was thrown at a reception center. To the north, in the border town of Tornio, 200 people formed a human chain to protest the arrival of Syrian, Iraqi and Afghan migrants from Sweden. No one was injured in any of the episodes.

Prime Minister Juha Sipila, who has offered to personally shelter refugees in his home, called the protests racist. "Finland is an international, open and tolerant country," with the majority of the population accepting of immigrants, he said in a joint statement with his finance and foreign ministers.

The Austro-Hungarian border has come into focus as one of the main nodes of the human exodus.

Up to 10,000 migrants have been entering Austria daily, mostly from Hungary; 134,000 made the crossing from Sept. 5 to 23, Austrian officials said Friday. While many of the migrants have continued on, to destinations like Germany and Sweden, 500 to 700 people each day have filed papers to stay in Austria, officials said.

After Hungary fenced off its border with Serbia last week, migrants turned to Croatia, entering Hungary through a different route — with the grudging acceptance of the Hungarian authorities — and then heading to Austria. Hungary on Friday continued to seal its border with Croatia, which like Serbia is not part of the passport-free Schengen travel zone that has been a cornerstone of European unity.

Austria's left-leaning chancellor, Werner Faymann, and Hungary's conservative prime minister, Viktor Orban, met in Vienna on Friday to discuss the situation. While they have divergent political stances, they agreed on the need for cooperation to manage the westward flow of immigrants.

The Austrians emphasized the European Union's procedures for accommodating and processing asylum seekers and described Hungary's fence construction along its borders with Serbia and Croatia as a matter for Hungarians to decide.

(Hungary has also placed a razor-wire barrier along parts of its border with Slovenia — which like Hungary is part of the Schengen zone — but on Friday, news reports from Slovenia said at least part of the wire fence had been taken down. Karl Erjavec, Slovenia's foreign minister, told state television that the Hungarian government had assured him that it would not extend the barrier along the entire 60-mile border between the two countries.)

Mr. Orban has considered tougher measures to seal the border with Croatia, but he pledged on Friday to consult Hungary's neighbors first. Criticized by humanitarian groups for his harsh language toward refugees, Mr. Orban on Friday described his objections as more pragmatic than ideological.

"Welcome parties — which certainly are proof of decency, and of which participating civic organizations can be proud — will give way to hardship and pragmatic concerns after a while," he said. "The situation will be hard politically and will not be easy humanly either."

In one positive sign, Croatia lifted a blockade of Serbian-registered vehicles along joint borders on Friday, ending a week of bickering, countermeasures and disintegrating relations, although resentment remained on both sides.

The measures were ostensibly introduced in retaliation for what Croatian officials said was Serbia's directing migrants to Croatian territory. But local business interests and the Croatian Chamber of Commerce said a prolonged two-way blockade of Serbian-registered vehicles and trucks carrying Croatian goods could cost the economies of both countries millions of euros.

"Our measures at the border may have been hard, but it was in defense of national interests and to control the flow of migrants who pass through Serbia without any control," said Croatia's prime minister, Zoran Milanovic, comparing government leaders to the notorious Serb strongman Slobodan Milosevic.

In Serbia, Interior Minister Nebojsa Stefanovic called the lifting of the blockade "a great victory for all citizens of Serbia," according to the Tanjug state news agency.

Mr. Stefanovic added that Prime Minister Aleksandar Vucic had scheduled a cabinet meeting for Friday evening and that he expected the agenda to include discussion of Serbia's repealing the countermeasures it adopted Thursday.

The diversity of the migrants — some have made their way to Europe from as far away as Afghanistan and Eritrea — has caught European leaders by surprise. While the four-year-old civil war in Syria has been one of the most obvious causes, United Nations officials are also pointing to the deteriorating situation in Iraq.

About 500,000 Iraqis could be displaced if the government, as expected, begins an offensive to retake the city of Mosul, which Islamic State forces captured last year, officials said in Geneva.

"The humanitarian situation is worsening dramatically," said Dominik Bartsch, the refugee agency's deputy coordinator in Iraq, citing a recent cholera outbreak and estimating that 10 million people, or one-quarter of the population, will need humanitarian aid by the end of the year.

Peter Webinger, deputy director of the department for migration and asylum affairs at Austria's Interior Ministry, said the new physical barriers would be a futile exercise.

"People on the move are like water," he said. "You put a barrier to stop it, and it will find a way to flow around it."

Kurdistan Regional Government
22 Sep 2015

KRG Ministry of Interior's Joint Crisis Coordination Centre statement on the humanitarian crisis

Without a significant increase in funding from the International Community and financial transactions from Government of Iraq, the Kurdistan Region will not be able to contain the humanitarian crisis.

The Kurdistan Regional Government has long adopted an inclusive and welcoming policy free of discrimination based on religious, cultural, ethnic or political identity. We recognize the vital importance of aiding those that are fleeing violence and unrest from other parts of Iraq in order to establish and maintain peace in this conflict-ridden area.

Kurdistan Region as a Safe Haven

From 2003 up until 2013, KRI opened its doors to more than 600,000 internally displaced Iraqis. The Government and the people of the Kurdistan Region understood that sustainable peace and development cannot be accomplished if some members of society are marginalized, and so we championed for inclusiveness by ensuring that these new members of our society were granted the same rights, protections and access to services.

Today, the Syrian civil war has produced one of the largest displacement crisis in the world and a significant number of Syrians fleeing violence have sought safety and shelter in the Kurdistan Region. In a sudden escalation of violence, the brutal invasion of the Islamic State in 2014 resulted in the forced displacement of three million Iraqis. The situation has rapidly developed into a full scale level-three humanitarian crisis. Offering protection and shelter, the Kurdistan Region once again became a safe haven for more than half of the displaced population and we have continued to keep our borders open.

Today, the Kurdistan Region is offering safety, protection and services to 280,000 Syrian refugees and up to 1.5 million IDPs. In 2014, an average of 80,000 IDPs entered the Kurdistan Region every month. These figures exclude the displaced populations served by the KRG in the neighboring provinces. As a result of multiple waves of displacement, the population of the Kurdistan Region has increased by almost 30%, placing immense pressure on existing resources and services. While the nature of the crisis challenges our ability to collect exact displacement figures, the number is significant enough to raise acute emergency alarms.

Containing an Extended Level-Three Crisis

The Government of Iraq has unconstitutionally withheld KRG's 17% share of the annual budget for the past 17 months. This has crippled the KRG's ability to maintain public services for the local population and meet the basic needs of the IDPs. Confronted with the trifecta of crises – loss of 90% of the fiscal transfers, the refugee and IDP crises and the war on ISIS – KRG cannot maintain its level of contribution and open-door policy without putting the safety and welfare of the population and stability of the Region at risk. Whilst the initial consequences are apparent, the full scale of the impacts is still unfolding due to the on-going nature and magnitude of the conflict. Up to date, the KRG has managed to contain the crisis and meet the basic needs of the affected populations with the assistance of UN Agencies and national and international NGOs. Yet the heaviest burden has been borne by the host communities, whose living standards, access to services and opportunities have drastically deteriorated over the past few years. Regrettably, the GoI has remained largely absent in the response to the IDP crisis in the Kurdistan Region despite its constitutional duty to its displaced citizens.

Contingency and Preparedness

In one of the world's most complex humanitarian crisis, the KRG and humanitarian partners on the ground are challenged to meet the deepening needs of a population in protracted displacement, while also responding to new emergencies and influxes. The military operations and subsequent displacements from Anbar have offered an insight into the likely outcomes of the anticipated liberation of Mosul. The worst case scenario is warning of the displacement of one million people. Based on previous displacement trends, geographic proximity, safety and security in the Kurdistan Region and the restricted access policies of other provinces in Iraq, the majority of the new IDPs will more than likely flee to the Kurdistan Region.

Preventing Regional Collapse

Over the past years, the refugee and IDP response plans have remained chronically underfunded. At its conclusion, the Strategic Response Plan had been funded at 26% while the corresponding figure for the Refugee Response stands at an alarming 19%. Adding to this pressured funding situation, the GoI has not only lacked in providing assistance but has

also withheld KRGs share of the national budget. In the recently launched Humanitarian Response Plan (HRP), the humanitarian community has appealed for \$500 million. If funded, the HRP will alleviate acute suffering but fall short of tackling the impact on host communities and society at large.

A recent report published by the World Bank and the Ministry of Planning estimates the cost of stabilising the region back to the pre-crisis level at \$1.4 billion under the baseline scenario, in which no new influx of displaced populations enter the Kurdistan Region. In the worst-case scenario, the World Bank and MoP have estimated a staggering need of \$2.4 billion for stabilization costs.

It is the regrettable conclusion of the KRG that without a drastic increase in funding from the international community and financial transactions from the GoI, the Region will neither be able to cope with the current crisis, nor respond to anticipated new displacements. As humanitarian partners formulate contingency plans, it is paramount to recognize that the Kurdistan Region has exhausted its response and absorption capacity and is at risk of total collapse.

KRG remains committed to its humanitarian responsibilities and will continue to voice the plight of the women, men and children in distress. We are calling on the international community and the GoI to provide the region with the necessary resources and technical support to continue offering a safe haven to those in need.

The New York Times
22 Sep 2015

As Others Flee to West, Most Syrian Refugees Remain in Region

By JODI RUDORENSEPT

ZAATARI REFUGEE CAMP, Jordan — Bicycles are the new basics for the world's largest concentration of Syrians who have fled their country's bloody civil war. Thousands traverse this camp's few paved roads and acres of rocky dirt, souped up with extra seats and milk crates to ferry groceries, bulky fans and small children.

Grown men ride hot-pink numbers, ringing tinny bells to clear their paths, to jobs in the sprawling souk or grunt work for aid groups. Boys adorn theirs with streamers and stickers, feathers and heart-shaped mirrors. The hourlong trudge to the supermarket on the camp's edge now takes 10 minutes on two wheels.

"This is what we have," Louay Al Hajj Ali, 37, said as he propelled a bicycle with his 1-year-old daughter and 4-month-old niece in a crate.

Mr. Ali's five simple words could serve as a motto for Zaatari, the eight-square-mile camp near Jordan's border with Syria now in its fourth year. Chaos and desperation have settled into an orderly grind, as the refugees' resignation and resilience combine with major infrastructure investments to make the place feel ever more like an entrenched city than a makeshift way station.

As the West grapples with a new flood of asylum seekers bursting across Europe's borders, the vast majority of Syrian refugees remain in the region: 1.9 million in Turkey, 1.2 million in Lebanon and 630,000 registered here in Jordan. Underfunded aid agencies and overburdened host countries have been struggling for years to support them.

With the World Food Program having cut vouchers this month to 229,000 Syrians living in Jordanian cities — where it is illegal for them to work — the once-reviled Zaatari (pronounced ZAHT-ah-ree) is increasingly seen as the most stable spot for refugees. While growing numbers yearn to join the exodus to Europe, many in the camp have all but surrendered to a life of limited possibilities.

Until recently, virtually every family imagined an imminent return to Syria as soon as President Bashar al-Assad fell. Now, many see their beloved homeland as lost, and grudgingly accept that Zaatari is somewhere they will be a while.

Refugees have planted vegetables, flowers, even trees that will not bear fruit for years in their compounds cobbled from corrugated tin and trailers. Unicef is spending \$37.7 million to install water and sewage systems and Germany \$20 million to build a solar field. A recent United Nations report estimated that residents run 2,500 shops — scores of new ones repair bicycles — generating \$14 million a month.

"We've become used to a system here, and a way of life," explained Ola Mahmeed, 26, a mother of five who was applying for a two-day "vacation" to visit relatives in nearby Irbid. "There's order, in terms of security, in terms of services. Anything I can think of I can find now in the market."

Zaatari's occupants say they would still jump at any chance to leave. Complaints are rife about electricity, which since June has been available only at night; rationed water; and, especially, the dismal quality of the schools. Last year, classes in the camp were crammed with up to 90 children; of those who took Jordan's 12th-grade exam, 3 percent passed.

The camp population has dropped to 79,000 from 83,000 in April (and 156,000 in March 2013).

While the rate of Syrians leaving Jordan has doubled to 120 per day in September from 60 in July, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees found that Zaatari residents are less likely to exit than those outside. Still, Hovig Etyemezian, the camp director, sees "an alarming trend" of young men selling land in Syria to finance precarious journeys to Europe.

"This is the way forward," said a 26-year-old who left on Sunday hoping to join a cousin in Stuttgart, Germany, or former Zaatari neighbors in the Netherlands and Sweden. "I have a degree, and for five years I have not worked with my degree," said the man, who was trained as a lab technician but has been selling stationery in Zaatari. "I want a career."

Bassem Zuhri, 42, would love to follow him — "I wish today I could leave" — but he cannot afford \$400 passports for his two wives and five children. Profits at Mr. Zuhri's bridal shop, where poofy dresses studded with rhinestones rent for \$25 a day, were slashed this summer by the \$155 monthly cost of a generator.

"We have established a life here," he said with a sigh, recalling the tough early days of flimsy tents and no water tanks. "There is everything, really, we need for now."

The trailers, each under 200 square feet, stretch dizzyingly in every direction.

Amid the vast monotone is a facade of faux green brick. Inside, the courtyard has a mural of mountains behind a lake with a tiny sailboat, cabin and young apple tree.

"He said, 'I'm going to paint you a new tree, without apples, because it kind of symbolizes your life here,'" said Suleiman Shalabi, 40, a barber with nine children, referring to a relative who decorated the place.

Others are planting actual trees — and corn, tomatoes, watermelon, even waist-high sunflowers that follow the light as it crosses the desert camp. Walid Lebad, 42, wheelbarrowed red soil from a construction site on the camp's edge to start his garden seven months ago, and recycles water from bathing and cooking to nurture it.

"This is called the white city: The sand is white, the caravan is white," said Mr. Lebad, a father of five.

"We don't want them to grow up without any color."

Ali Suleiman, 23, said the sweet chirping of the four yellow canaries he keeps in cages "makes us forget where we are."

Khaled Zoubi, 36, started selling the birds about a year ago. As winter waned, he planted an olive tree and a lemon tree in the courtyard, though he rejected any suggestion that he, too, is growing roots in Zaatari.

"As long as we're here, it's as if I'm going to live here forever," he explained. "But if I had an opportunity, I would leave, even on 24 hours' notice."

If schools are the barometer of any community, Zaatari gets poor grades. Parents complain that children learn little. Teachers lament pupils who disappear for months at a time and scant supplies.

"The student comes, he says, 'I don't have a pencil' — where should I get him a pencil?" said Fahed Khazalaah, assistant principal at School No. 3, where only three boys showed up for one class recently.

The United Nations says 20,000 of Zaatari's 29,000 school-age children were enrolled last year. It is tripling the number of school sites this year to bring down class size — to a maximum of 50.

There are also 32 "informal education" centers where dropouts take courses in computers, welding and electrical wiring. Mr. Etyemezian, the camp director, said he was trying to make arrangements for college classes. "That is the single biggest worry I have: these generations of Syrians who are being born here, and their parents are saying why would I send them to school if there are no opportunities," he said. "With infrastructure, fine, you have challenges that affect everyday life. With education, it's the entire future of the Syrians."

Infrastructure is its own mountain.

With electric bills nearing \$1 million a month and the camp's grid groaning from overuse — washing machines and televisions are not officially allowed but ubiquitous — Mr. Etyemezian pulled the plug in June. Refugees spent the sweaty summer with as little as six hours of electricity each night (it is now eight).

Rationing is likely to continue until the solar field is finished next year. It will be months, too, until Unicef standardizes the bathrooms most refugees built to avoid the fetid communal ones, and installs 2,500 water tanks, aiming to eliminate the 300 daily truck trips that bring water in and take waste out.

Such huge projects suggest aid workers see a long life span for the camp. "We don't really ask that question that much," Mr. Etyemezian said. "What we are saying already is the longer-term development infrastructure is cheaper and more efficient and more dignified."

"The first bicycles started showing up more than a year ago, but the boom came around Amsterdam's April donation of 400 broken-down two-wheelers that had been abandoned on its streets. Zaatari's entrepreneurs smuggled in hordes more.

One shiny silver bike bears a Reebok sticker and British flag, a black one says "PROSPERITY" on the crossbar, and another has the faded moniker of Gazelle NL, a Dutch model that retails for about \$500. Most bikes sell for about \$100, refugees said; new tires run \$10 to \$15. The padded, fringed seats sewn from Oriental fabrics go for \$1.50.

"You cannot even start to know how much it has changed our lives," said Issa Suleiman, 28. "It's a very basic necessity. It has made life more bearable."

Just barely bearable.

Ali Al Humsi, 25, moved to Zaatari nine months ago, upon the birth of his daughter, Nuha, after trying for two years to scratch by in Jordanian cities. He and a friend commute on a single bicycle to the center where he teaches barber skills in the morning; afternoons, he cuts hair in his own shop.

After dinner, Mr. Humsi sometimes strums the oud or plays the recorder for neighbors. Then he sits with his wife, drinking Nescafé and arguing over whether to stay or go.

"We are like living in the Dark Ages mentally," he added. "The other day I said a verse of Arabic poetry to a friend that means, 'How hard life would be if not for hope.' My friend said, 'Forget about hope, let's go buy some tomatoes.'"

Initiatives of Change International (IOCI)

16 Sep 2015

<http://www.iofc.org/refugees-gift-not-threat>

Refugees a gift not a threat

by Edward Peters

"Attitude is everything" is a well-known maxim. Our chances of overcoming a problem, according to this philosophy, depend largely on our attitude to it.

With refugees pouring into Europe by the tens of thousands, our attitude to this 'crisis' may not be everything. But if we don't unuddle the thinking in our heads, the consequences could be catastrophic – for them and for us.

So much of the current debate is centred on our ourselves – whether we can cope, how we will be affected. Of course these issues are important, but there is more at stake here.

As Europeans we need to reboot our brains, shedding the notion that these people are a threat, and coming to see them as a gift instead.

A gift? How can that be when many European countries are already struggling with economic inequalities, unemployment, ethnic tension?

We may find that these fleeing people, poor in possessions, but rich in experience and values, may help us in ways we have not imagined.

Their humanity could rekindle our humanity. As we become more aware of the smallness of our often-self-preoccupied lives, we might begin to find a new and deeper motivation. Already we see the crisis bringing out the best in people, as the latent generosity in so many Europeans is unleashed. It could lead to a renewed sense of purpose – amid the drifting aimlessness gripping our continent – to help shape societies which provide justice for all.

Another gift could be an opportunity to atone for the wrongs of the past. As everyone knows, whether we admit it or not, Europe bears a heavy responsibility for the breakdown of nations and communities in many of the countries from which the refugees are fleeing. For centuries we have acted largely out of self-interest without thought of the consequences. Here is a chance to help redress the balance.

A new humility and integrity in the West might give us more credibility, too, in playing a role in helping Syria to stop bleeding. We cannot ignore our responsibility to help in stabilising the region and bringing a settlement to the Syrian conflict.

And then perhaps another gift is on offer here. The true happiness that comes from sharing, from caring for those in need. Much of our Western society is based on the notion that happiness comes from getting what you want, but in our heart of hearts we know that isn't true. Here is a chance to experience the real thing.

Yes, seeing these people as a gift to us, instead of as a threat to our comfortable isolation, could be the change of mindset which would release new ideas and fresh teamwork across the continent. What this might mean in terms of hard government policies is another matter. But attitude, if not everything, is fundamental to find a way forward.

Edward Peters is a member of the International Council of Initiatives of Change International (www.iofc.org). He is writing in his personal capacity. He lives in Sweden.

The New York Times
5 Sep 2015
SundayReview | OPINION

The Refugee Crisis Isn't a 'European Problem'

By MICHAEL IGNATIEFF

Michael Ignatieff is a professor at the Harvard Kennedy School of Government where formerly he served as director of the Carr Center for Human Rights Policy, where current US Ambassador to the UN Samantha Power was founding executive director. He is also an author and former Canadian politician.

THOSE of us outside Europe are watching the unbelievable images of the Keleti train station in Budapest, the corpse of a toddler washed up on a Turkish beach, the desperate Syrian families chancing their lives on the night trip to the Greek islands — and we keep being told this is a European problem.

The Syrian civil war has created more than four million refugees. The United States has taken in about 1,500 of them. The United States and its allies are at war with the Islamic State in Syria — fine, everyone agrees they are a threat — but don't we have some responsibility toward the refugees fleeing the combat? If we've been arming Syrian rebels, shouldn't we also be helping the people trying to get out of their way? If we've failed to broker peace in Syria, can't we help the people who can't wait for peace any longer?

It's not just the United States that keeps pretending the refugee catastrophe is a European problem. Look at countries that pride themselves on being havens for the homeless. Canada, where I come from? As few as 1,074 Syrians, as of August. Australia? No more than 2,200. Brazil? Fewer than 2,000, as of May.

The worst are the petro states. As of last count by Amnesty International, how many Syrian refugees have the Gulf States and Saudi Arabia taken in? Zero. Many of them have been funneling arms into Syria for years, and what have they done to give new homes to the four million people trying to flee? Nothing.

The brunt of the crisis has fallen on the Turks, the Egyptians, the Jordanians, the Iraqis and the Lebanese. Funding appeals by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees have failed to meet their targets. The squalor in the refugee camps has become unendurable. Now the refugees have decided, en masse, that if the international community won't help them, if neither Russia nor the United States is going to force the war to an end, they won't wait any longer. They are coming our way. And we are surprised?

Blaming the Europeans is an alibi and the rest of our excuses — like the refugees don't have the right papers — are sickening.

Political leadership from outside Europe could reverse the paralysis and mutual recrimination inside Europe. The United Nations system to register refugees is overwhelmed. Countries like Hungary say they can't resettle them all on their own. The obvious solution is for Canada, Australia, the United States, Brazil and other countries to announce that they are willing to send processing teams to Budapest, Athens and the other major entry points to register refugees and process them for admission.

Countries will set their own targets, but for the United States and Canada, for example, a minimum of 25,000 Syrian refugees is a good place to start. (The United States' recent promise to take in 5,000 to 8,000 Syrian refugees next year is still far too small.) Churches, mosques, community groups and families could agree to sponsor and resettle refugees. Most of the burdened countries — Hungary, Greece, Turkey, Italy — would accept help in a heartbeat. Once these states take a lead, other countries — including those wretched autocrats in the Gulf States — could be shamed into doing their part.

So why are our leaders — President Obama, Prime Minister Stephen Harper, Prime Minister Tony Abbott and President Dilma Rousseff — doing so little? Resettling refugees, they fear, will trigger an even greater exodus, and they don't know how their teams could handle the chaos that would result. Tough, resourceful management — clear quotas for Syrian refugees (especially those with young families), simplified procedures and a commitment to airlift people out quickly — could solve these problems.

Most of all, however, leaders aren't acting because no one back home is putting any pressure on them. Now, thanks to heart-sickening photographs, let's hope the pressure grows.

This is a truly biblical movement of refugees and it demands a global response. If governments won't help refugees escape Syria, smugglers and human traffickers will, and the deadly toll will rise.

Once the Europeans know that their democratic friends are ready to take in their fair share, it will become easier for them to take theirs, and the momentum might emerge to reform the 1951 Refugee Convention, so that all those fleeing civil war, state collapse and murderous militias will get the same protection as those fleeing a well-founded fear of persecution.

Let's remember that we used to be able to rise to the occasion. My country, Canada, sent a government minister to Vienna in late 1956 to support a processing center that took in hundreds of Hungarians and airlifted them to Canada after the Soviets crushed the Hungarian uprising. The Hungarians themselves seem to forget that they, too, were once refugees. In the late 1970s and early 1980s, Canada, Australia, New Zealand and the United States received hundreds of thousands of

Vietnamese boat people. There were voices, on both occasions, that warned, this will trigger a flood. It did — and what excellent citizens these Vietnamese and Hungarians have been.

The Vietnamese and Hungarians were fleeing Communism. What's holding back sympathy for the Syrians? They've been barrel-bombed in Aleppo by their own regime, they've been tortured, kidnapped and massacred by miscellaneous jihadis and opposition militias. They've been in refugee camps for years, waiting for that cruelly deceiving fiction "the international community" to come to their aid. Now, when they take to the roads, to the boats and to the trains, all our political leaders can think of is fences, barbed wire and more police.

What must Syrians, camped on the street outside the Budapest railway station, be thinking of all that fine rhetoric of ours about human rights and refugee protection? If we fail, once again, to show that we mean what we say, we will be creating a generation with abiding hatred in its heart.

So if compassion won't do it, maybe prudence and fear might. God help us if these Syrians do not forgive us our indifference.

LobeLog
17 Sep 2015

The Roots of the Current Refugee Crisis

by Shireen Hunter

Discussions surrounding Europe's most recent migration crisis have been framed largely in ethical and humanitarian terms. The most frequently asked questions have been about how Europe can live up to its own humanitarian values and accept as many refugees as possible. Those European countries that have seemingly fallen short on this score have been scolded. Meanwhile, focusing on how to stem the tide of refugees, other commentators have argued that the solution lies in ending the conflict in Syria.

Clearly, these are legitimate issues and need to be addressed. However, they do not go to the root causes of the dramatic increase in the number of refugees coming to Europe—and the US and elsewhere, such as Australia—in the last four decades. Yet, without addressing these fundamental issues no long-term and effective way of dealing with the recurring crisis of sudden and unregulated migration can be found.

Meanwhile, migration is changing the face of Europe, creating new tensions within European societies and negatively affecting their politics. Other recipient countries are also affected by migration. It is no use to say that people should be welcoming, tolerant, and embrace multiculturalism. These are worthy sentiments and certainly should be encouraged. However, social and political realities tell a different story: excessive migration, especially of people with totally different cultural and religious characteristics from those of recipient countries, is neither good for the immigrants or for the local people. The immigrants feel shunned and find integration problematic, and the locals feel that too much is expected of them.

Underdevelopment and Poverty

Many immigrants to Europe have come for economic reasons from the Middle East, North Africa, Africa, and the Caribbean. Even some asylum seekers have partially been motivated by economic factors. In the 1960s and early 1970s, Europe largely welcomed these immigrants since it was undergoing rapid post-war economic reconstruction and expansion. By the 1980s, the Europeans had grown weary of immigrants and their descendants as well as the social tensions that had developed with the local people. Yet the less welcoming atmosphere did not lessen the desire of many to emigrate to Europe, particularly from the Middle East and North Africa. This desire was reflected in the chants of "visa, visa" that greeted President Jacques Chirac during a visit to Algeria in March 2003. Later polls indicated that an overwhelming majority of Moroccan youths wanted to emigrate to France or other European countries if they could. The desire to reach Europe at times has been so intense that migrants have risked their lives by perilous sea voyage.

Behind this intense desire to reach Europe and other rich countries has been the failure of the development process in the majority of what used to be known as the Third World. The economic gap between the haves and the have nots has grown, both within the countries and between the rich and poor countries, or what was known as the North and the South, terms and concepts almost totally forgotten now. The failure of the development process had many and mostly domestic sources.

However, factors related to the international political and economic system, including the Cold War and the interventionist policies of the protagonists, also contributed to this failure. In some cases, these interventions took the form of proxy wars that not only arrested the development process but in some instances devastated the countries, Afghanistan being a prime example. In the 1980s, with the popularity of the belief in market forces as a panacea for everything from population control to agricultural production, development issues took a backseat not only in government policy circles but also in academia. In the 1990s, globalization became the buzzword and the purported solution to all global economic problems. However, globalization only accentuated economic disparities within and among states.

As a result, the urge among the poor of the world to reach rich countries remained and even increased. In short, immigration has been largely the outcome of this ever-growing economic gap. As long as this gap exists the pressure to migrate will remain. Meanwhile, many people in the receiving countries are growing weary of the cultural and social fallouts of immigration, presaging potential social disturbances. Thus, to solve the problem of immigration, development issues again need to be addressed as a global concern for all.

After the end of the Cold War, some naively hoped that large sums previously spent on armaments by both big powers and such rich small states as the oil producers of the Persian Gulf could be devoted instead to development across the globe. Sadly, these hopes were disappointed. Instead some argued that, with the Soviet Union gone, there was no need to fight "for the hearts and minds" of people in the developing world, and therefore no need to help them develop. Instead a new era of intervention and reordering of the world began.

Revolution, War, and Migration

There has always been a direct connection between war, revolution, and migration. Revolutions upset the existing social and political order, forcing those threatened by change to leave their homeland. For example, the Iranian revolution led to a massive migration of the Iranian middle classes to Europe, America, and Australia. The collapse of the Haile Selassie regime in Ethiopia and the dysfunctional policies of his successors started a wave of Ethiopian refugees, later followed by those from Somalia. Even less dramatic political changes often lead to migration. For example, Idi Amin's policy of so-called Ugandanization of Uganda led the country's South Asian population to leave the country, mostly in the direction of the UK. Something similar happened in Kenya.

Wars also lead to migration. In the 1980s, the Afghan war led to the first wave of Afghan immigrants to Europe and the US and even more so to the neighboring countries of Iran and Pakistan. The Iran-Iraq war caused many Iraqis to move to Iran and to other countries. The Bosnian war resulted in the influx of people from the Balkans into other parts of Europe, especially Germany. Subsequent wars in Iraq, Somalia, Libya, and Syria have been a main cause of the rising wave of refugees and migrants. Soon we may witness a surge of refugees from Yemen and wherever the next war breaks out. Refugees, meanwhile, rarely return home and often become immigrants.

As economic migrants have been the consequence of the failure of the development process to narrow the global economic gap, revolutions and wars have been the consequence of the political shortcomings of both migrant-generating countries and those of the international system. A portion of immigrants and asylum seekers leave their countries because of political repression. Revolutions and civil wars also reflect the breakdown of political systems and the inability of governments to peacefully mediate differences. However, external intervention and the propensity of many international actors to manipulate internal divisions within weaker states and ignore international norms has always contributed to such developments. In the post-Cold War era, the arrogance of the great powers in their attempt to bend the outside world to their will without much concern for local realities, as well as their flouting of international law, has greatly contributed to the increase in war and violence, especially in the Middle East. Meanwhile, countries in the region have followed their example by embarking on aggressive actions against their neighbors. A good example is the Saudi intervention in Yemen, which has devastated an already fragile country.

Migration: The Revenge of the Neglected?

The British historian Arnold Toynbee is reputed to have said that migration is the punishment for the sin of colonialism. This observation may or may not be true. But it is certainly the case that the neglect of large parts of the globe and their peoples, along with the continuing practice of treating them as faceless pawns on the chessboard of world politics, has been largely responsible for the refugee and migration problems, including the latest crisis.

Recurring refugee problems and the continuing flow of migrants show that the rich and the powerful can no longer shield themselves from the consequences of their actions. The world has grown smaller and problems of one part affect conditions in other parts of the globe.

It is time for all world leaders to forget about their egos and their ambitions to dominate. It is time to dust off some old and forgotten concepts, such as peace, development, cooperation, justice, and the rule of international law. The international community must start moving towards construction and not destruction in order to find global solutions to global problems. This may sound naïve. But can anyone come up with a better alternative?

The RAND Blog
15 Sep 2015

Putting a Human Face on the Refugee Crisis

by Obaid Younossi

Obaid Younossi is a senior management scientist at the nonprofit, nonpartisan RAND Corporation.

As the world watches — often with alarm — as the worst refugee crisis in a quarter-century unfolds, it's important to view the potential immigrants for what they can be: productive members of their newly adopted countries.

Thirty-five years ago, I was one of those refugees, embarking on a harrowing journey as my family fled the horrors of the Soviet-backed regime in Afghanistan.

Now, like then, men, women and children in desperate situations are gambling with their lives and using whatever means they can in an attempt to escape the misery of war-torn or impoverished countries in the hope of securing a better life in the West.

There is drama and heartache in the headlines. In recent days, 71 would-be refugees, most likely from Syria, were left to suffocate on the side of a road in Austria, abandoned and locked inside the back of an airless truck. Off the coast of Libya, 51 bodies were found in the hold of a ship and another 150 people were presumed drowned after two boats capsized.

The Mediterranean Sea has been called “the world's deadliest border” because so many desperately seeking asylum have died trying to cross it — more than 2,600 this year, according to the International Organization for Migration. The mistreatment often begins with smugglers, who dangerously pack the refugees onto small boats that were likely not designed to cross any sea.

More than 300,000 refugees have tried to cross the Mediterranean this year, the United Nations reports. The lucky ones make it to Europe, but often find no refuge. Instead, they are greeted by razor-wire fences like the one Hungary built to essentially close its borders. Or they receive a message that they are clearly unwanted, one that is telegraphed by states squabbling over how to handle the influx of immigrants and an absence of centers to help meet their needs and process them.

The United States had taken in fewer than 1,000 Syrian refugees as of June but will accept

between 5,000 to 8,000 next year, the State Department announced in late August. The sheer number of people fleeing war-torn countries can make the refugees seem faceless. More than 4 million in Syria have become homeless since civil war broke out in that country in 2010, according to media reports.

My family is a reminder of the human faces attached to those numbers. We were once as desperate as the Syrian refugees are today. We contemplated being smuggled across the border to Pakistan in our after-dinner conversations and whispered exchanges between my parents.

Every family we knew tried to get their kids out by any means possible. Families were broken apart, children sent in different directions — anywhere as long as they were out of immediate harm.

I was 18, a student and still too young for conscription, and applied for a passport under the pretense that I was accompanying a “sick” cousin to seek treatment abroad. I soon left Afghanistan and the “sick” cousin behind.

My older brother, then a medical student, walked for days with smugglers to make it across the Pakistan border. Upon arriving, he found out that our cousin Shahwali, a brilliant 20-year-old in his second year of medical school, had suffocated in the back of a truck while being smuggled out of Afghanistan. He died in the arms of his older brother in the border town of Peshawar. Their father had been shot dead months before while driving to an early anti-government protest in Afghanistan.

The rest of my immediate family fled Afghanistan within months of my departure. They waited in India to receive asylum from the United States while my brother and I waited in Italy for our visas. By 1982, the seven members of my immediate family were reunited in America, bruised and facing an uncertain future in an unfamiliar place but buoyed by the hopes and dreams in a place that had been billed as the land of opportunity.

And opportunity we found. Everyone in my family worked hard, seemingly harder than our American peers, to achieve our version of the American dream and make a lasting mark. When I see news photographs of bodies of refugees that have washed up on the shores of Europe, I often think of the stunning loss of my amazing cousin, whose dreams died along with him in that container truck. How much more air would he have needed to be able to continue his journey of hope? His siblings who made it to the United States became a physician, computer scientist, businessman and a public servant.

As politicians in the West struggle with how to deal with this incredible surge in refugees, the world needs to remember to treat them humanely and with dignity. They are people, awaiting their fate. By welcoming and accepting them, the West can send their oppressors a message regarding what it means to be a free democratic society.